

SWAMPEELS AND RELATIVES

These tropical and subtropical freshwater fish have an eel-like body and most Synbranchiformes have tiny or no fins. This makes it easy for them to slither through swamps and marshes and burrow in mud.



FIRE EEL

Mastacembelus erythrotaenia
F: Mastacembelidae

Living in flooded lowland plains and slow rivers in S.E. Asia, this edible spiny eel feeds on insect larvae and worms.

1 m
3 1/4 ft

MARBLED SWAMPEEL

Synbranchus marmoratus
F: Synbranchidae

Able to breathe air if necessary, this almost finless fish survives in very small bodies of water in C. and S. America.



1.5 m
5 ft

FLATFISH

Pleuronectiformes start life in the plankton as normal upright juveniles. As they grow, they become flattened sideways and lie on one side on the seabed. The underneath eye migrates round to join the other on the upper side.



EUROPEAN PLAICE

Pleuronectes platessa
F: Pleuronectidae

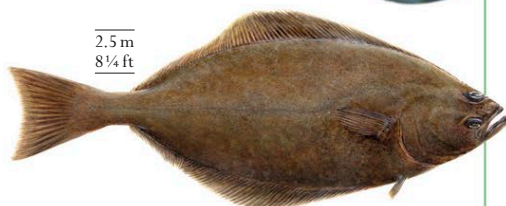
This North Atlantic commercial flatfish lies camouflaged on the seabed with its right side uppermost. It emerges at night to feed.

1 m
3 1/4 ft

ATLANTIC HALIBUT

Hippoglossus hippoglossus
F: Pleuronectidae

One of the largest flatfish, the Atlantic halibut lies on its left side with both eyes on the upward-facing right side.



2.5 m
8 1/4 ft



COMMON SOLE

Solea solea
F: Soleidae

Although they can live to be 30 years old, most sole do not survive this long as they are a valuable commercial fish.

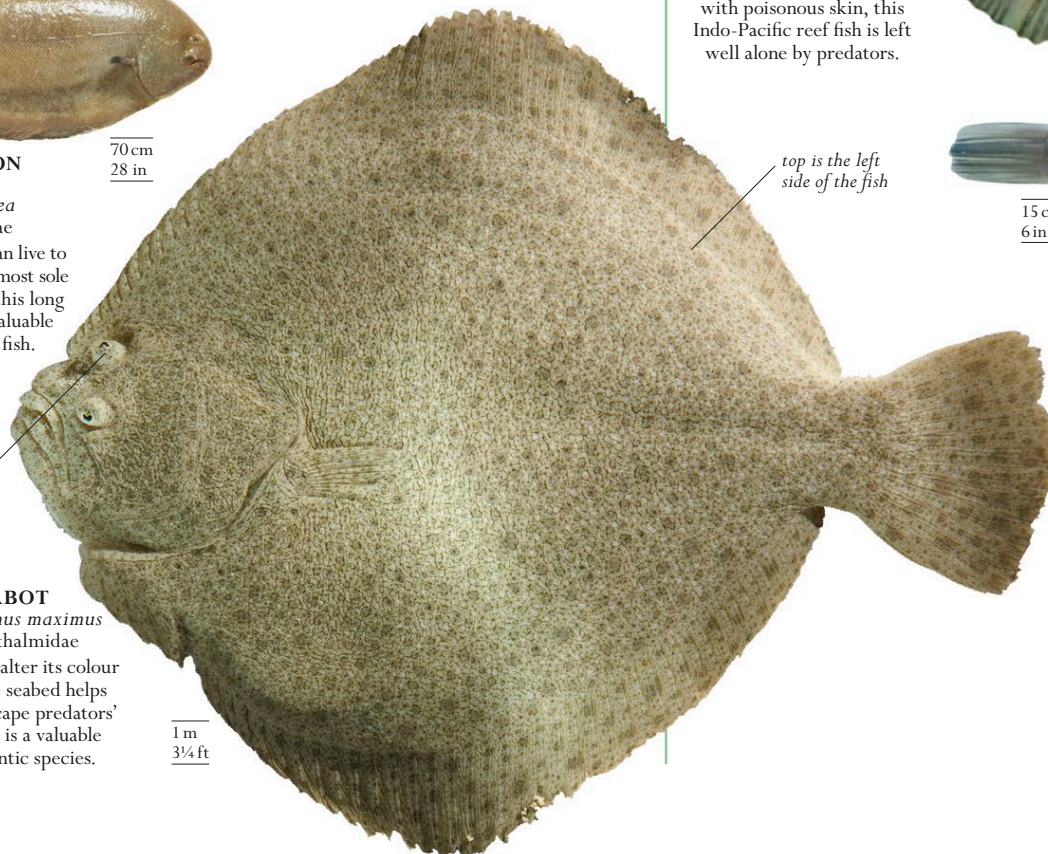
70 cm
28 in

TURBOT

Scophthalmus maximus
F: Scophthalmidae

The ability to alter its colour to match the seabed helps the turbot escape predators' attention. It is a valuable North Atlantic species.

1 m
3 1/4 ft

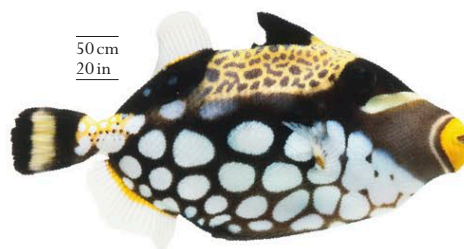


right eye has moved to top of the fish

top is the left side of the fish

TRIGGERFISH, PUFFERFISH, AND RELATIVES

This diverse group of marine and freshwater fish includes the huge ocean sunfish and the poisonous pufferfish. Instead of normal teeth, the Tetraodontiformes have fused tooth plates or just a few large teeth. Their scales are modified to form protective spines or plates.

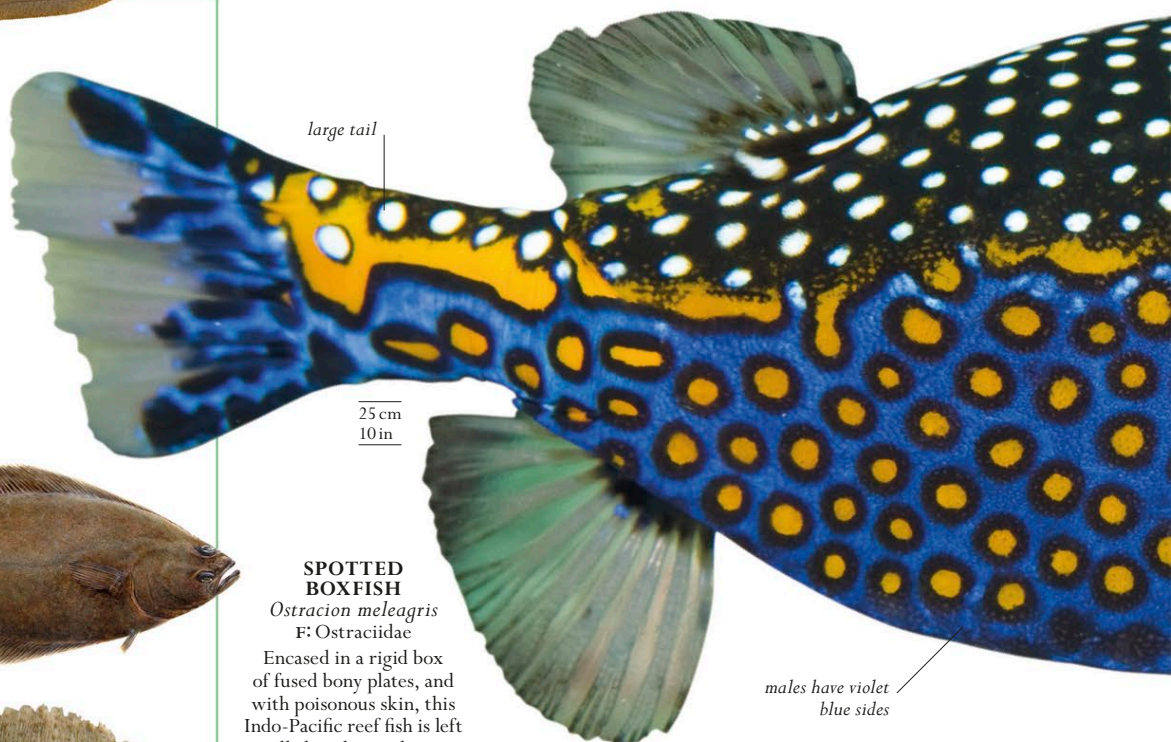


CLOWN TRIGGERFISH

Balistoides conspicillum
F: Balistidae

This brightly coloured coral-reef fish can wedge itself in a crevice by erecting its dorsal spines, which lock in position.

50 cm
20 in



large tail

25 cm
10 in

SPOTTED BOXFISH

Ostracion meleagris
F: Ostraciidae

Encased in a rigid box of fused bony plates, and with poisonous skin, this Indo-Pacific reef fish is left well alone by predators.

males have violet blue sides



15 cm
6 in

WHITE-SPOTTED PUFFER

Arothron hispidus
F: Tetraodontidae

The neurotoxin contained within the skin and organs of this fish can easily kill a human and deters natural predators.



50 cm
20 in

LONG-SPINE PORCUPINEFISH

Diodon holocanthus
F: Diodontidae

Found in all tropical seas, this spiny fish can suck in water to inflate its body and turn itself into a prickly ball – a very effective deterrent against predators.